Dreamland

By Sarah Dessen

CAITLIN: My sister, Cassandra, had been the best at everything, even when it came to boys. She'd spend hours on the phone at night telling her latest boyfriend goodbye, this involving about twenty-I love you's and pet names like "my little pumpkin". Little did we know she was planning on leaving to be with her latest in California.

CASSANDRA: Oh, Caitlin, someday this will happen to you! You won't feel like you're missing out!

CAITLIN: God, I hope not. If I act like that, be sure to put me out of my misery.

But that was before I met Rogerson Biscoe. He was standing next to this black BMW; brown mass of curls; so mysterious and very different. I had never seen any other guy like him and at that moment, I could see myself setting across uncharted territory, places I'd never been or seen or even heard of. My world was suddenly wide and limitless, and I was ready.

INTRODUCTION

As humans, we may want to focus on reality but sometimes catch ourselves. . . daydreaming. Daydreaming has the power to take us away from pushy parents, a difficult class at school, or work. But what if this semi-conscious dreamland is suddenly turned into a living nightmare?

In this selection, a nightmare slowly overtakes Caitlin who seeks out Rogerson as an escape from her reality: A missing sister, a withdrawn mother and an overall lackluster life. But she soon comes to realize that semi-conscious dreamlands aren't always an escape.

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CAITLIN: I was hooked on him. With Rogerson I was someone else. There were so many things I already loved about him. The smell of his skin, the way he pressed his hand in to the small of my back, whenever I walked into any place with him. And he was so attentive, always keeping one eye on me regardless of what else he was doing.

Since Cassandra was gone, my parents thought it would be good for me to join something. My making cheerleader changed my mother's life. But the truth was, I hated cheerleading.

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Whatever pep the other girls had was missing in me, like a genetic or chemical malfunction. I felt like an imposter, and it showed. And after Rogerson and I started going together, cheerleading meant nothing to me.

Rogerson was always there. He drove me home everyday. And we never really went on dates. With Rogerson, it was all about being in motion. Going from party to party, place to place. And, of course, there were the drugs. Rogerson operated a brisk business selling pot and other various illegals to the kids around town. The more I was around Rogerson, the less I became involved with my friend Rina and cheerleading.

Sometimes, however, Rogerson wouldn't talk and he just wanted to be near me. It was never clear. But I did know this: he was quiet and never spoke without thinking. That he drove like a maniac. That the only time I saw the small simmering of temper behind his cool demeanor was when someone was late or not where they said they'd be. He was punctual to the second.

And I guess that's what made my perfect relationship slide on through. Everything was perfect... before I missed his ride to the Winter Athletic Ceremony at school. Before he hit me. It was like a crack, like a gunshot. And it wasn't like in the movies, where the person just stands there and takes it. I reeled back hitting my head against the seat of his car. He acted like what he had done was my fault. And after that, he drove me home, like nothing had happened, nothing at all.

It was during this time that I took up photography. Despite the fact that cheerleading was going from bad to worse, taking pictures was the first thing I had done in a long time that I was truly proud of. Until Rogerson saw me talking to my photography class instructor. He punched me in the jaw as soon as I got in his car. I convinced my mother when I got home that I had "slipped on the ice" by the mailbox.

MOTHER: It's just so red. You must have hit so hard.

CAITLIN: I felt as if I couldn't tell anyone about Rogerson-as long as I didn't say it out loud, it wasn't real.

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As if by silent agreement since that night, Rogerson had taken only to hitting me where I could cover it. I wore only long-sleeved shirts, big sweaters, and turtlenecks, but at least now my face was off-limits.

On Christmas Eve, he gave me this beautiful silver necklace and that night, I slept with him for the first time. It was then that I gave him all of me, believing that I could trust him.

There was no pattern, no way of knowing when to expect it. Whenever he did hit me, I could count on a 24-hour safe period, which I had come to rely on, like home base. Those were the good days. But no matter what we were doing, the fact that he hit me was always on my mind.

One day, he was working on his car and I glanced at my reflection in the chrome of the bumper in front of me: skinny, long baggy shirt hiding the bruises across my skin and bones like a road map of all that had happened, every mile of the journey. And it was getting harder to hide.

See, my family always has this April Fool's Party in the backyard, a small neighborhood get-together and my mom was just so determined to get me to wear this short white swooshy-skirted dress. It was beautiful, the kind of dress you wore with bare legs, uncovered arms, and white strappy sandals.

MOTHER: I'm concerned, Caitlin. All you ever wear now is black. An occasional red or white, but that's it. You know how nice you always looked in blue.

CAITLIN: And I kept thinking, 'I still do, look here, on the back of my wrist, those two spots the size of fingertips. Or here at the base of my back; that's blue, too.' I looked up into her face, but she didn't seem to see me, even as I pleaded that she would.

My parents had no idea until the night of that party. Rogerson and I were supposed to hang out that day, but Rina had kidnapped me, taking me to the lake. I tried calling him, many times, but he just wouldn't pick up.

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I arrived home late, and his car was already parked in front. It didn't take him long to start grabbing at me, pushing me around. His fist came and hit me right over my left eye and that's when I slid down onto the grass and stayed there. I tried rolling away from him, but everything hurt all at once; my face, my fingers, the back of my head, the skin itself. Each place he'd ever struck me, like old war wounds on rainy days.

He was still pleading with me to get up when my mother came running outside. She wrapped her arms around me, trying to find a spot that wasn't hurt. And even after my father called the police and they led Rogerson away, I still pulled out of the hands of all my family and friends, sobbing, screaming, everything hurting, to try and make him stay.

After that night, when my dreams of Rogerson were finally shattered, I was admitted into the Evergreen Care Center. The irony in this is just a few years back my sister and I had made fun of their slogan, "We can't heal you at Evergreen, but we can help you heal yourself." I'd cried for Rogerson and for myself. How had I let it get so far? It was easier to take the days in tiny swallows, rather than biting everything off at once, and I was learning how to heal myself day by day with the help of my many visitors who cared so much about me.

A month went by and they finally decided I was well enough to go home. Before stepping outside my room, I looked up at my mirror. I looked so different from the day I'd arrived. I'd gained weight, my hair was longer, my skin clearer. I lowered my camera to my waist, tilting it upward. Then I put my finger on the shutter and smiled at the girl in the mirror. She smiled back, and I knew she understood it all, what I had gone through to make it this far. This is who I wanted to be. This was the person who I needed to become. So I kept my eyes on hers, steady, and pressed down on the button of the camera to catch this final face.

Click.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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